

FOREFATHER OF THE MODERN RIFLE

BAKER RIFLE

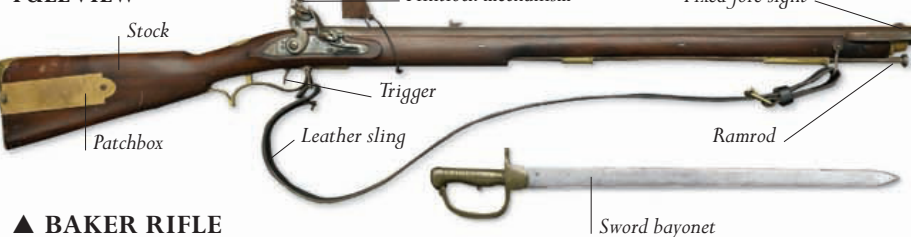
In February 1800, the Baker rifle won a competition organized by the Army's Board of Ordnance and became the first rifle officially adopted by the British Army. It was similar to weapons in use in Germany, and its novel feature lay in its barrel. With shallow or "slow" rifling – just a quarter-turn in the length of the barrel – it stayed clean and thus usable for longer, a great practical advantage for the rifleman in the field. It was superseded from 1837 by the heavier, muzzle-loading Brunswick rifle.

▼ RIFLE

Ezekiel Baker's rifle was a robust weapon, designed to keep on working even under the most difficult conditions, and several modifications to the original design reflected that. With its short barrel – 76cm (30in) instead of the more customary 100cm (39in) – it was not particularly accurate, but was still a great improvement over the smooth-bore musket then in general use.



FULL VIEW



▲ BAKER RIFLE

Date 1800

Origin Britain

Weight 4kg (9lb)

Barrel 76cm (30in)

Calibre .625in

Jaw screw

Top jaw

Flint

Cock

Steel

Pan

Protective cover
for cock and steelLock based on New
Land-System

Armoury mark

Brass escutcheon

Trigger

Brass trigger guard

Rolled cowhide head

Beechwood
shaft

IN ACTION

ON THE
BATTLEFIELD

The Baker rifle was used by many British Army regiments, including the 95th (Rifle) Regiment, raised specifically to exploit the Baker, and the Duke of Cumberland's Sharpshooters. It saw early action at Ferrol, in Spain, in 1800, and later, to great effect in the Peninsular War of 1808–14.

► A Sharpshooter steadies his rifle using its sling.



◀ MALLET

To begin with, small mallets – used to tap the ramrod, to ram down the ball – were issued, but were soon found to be unnecessary. Hand pressure alone was sufficient.